

The DECLARATION of INDEPENDENCE

IN CONGRESS, JULY 4, 1776.

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America,

When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation. — We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness. — That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, — That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such Principles and organizing its Powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness. — Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. — But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security. — Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies, and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former system of Government. — The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. — To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world. — He has refused his assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good. — He has forbidden his Governors to pass Laws of immediate and pressing importance, unless suspended in their operation, till his assent should be obtained; and when so suspended, he has utterly neglected to attend to them. — He has refused to pass other Laws for the accommodation of large districts of People, unless those People would consent to the deposition of their Representatives, a right in themselves, and parcelled to their Representatives only. — He has called together legislative Bodies at places unusual, uncomfortable, and distant from the depository of their Public Records, for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measures. — He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the People. — He has refused, for a long time after such Dissolutions, to cause others to be elected; whereby the Legislative Powers, incapable of Annihilation, have returned to the People at large, for their exercise; the State remaining in the mean time exposed to all the dangers of Invasion from without, and convulsions within. — He has endeavored to prevent the Population of these States, for that purpose obstructing the Law for Naturalization of Strangers; refusing to pass others to encourage their migrations hither, and raising the conditions of new Appropriations of Lands. — He has obstructed the Administration of Justice, by refusing his assent to Laws for establishing Judiciary Powers. — He has made Judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries. — He has created a multitude of new Offices, and sent swarms of Officers to harass our People, and eat out their substance. — He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our Legislature. — He has endeavored to bring on the most barbarous and inhuman War of civil blood, by declaring us out of his Protection and waging War against us. — He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns, and destroyed the lives of our People. — He is at this time harassing large Numbers of foreign Mercenaries to combat the works of death, desolation and tyranny, already begun with circumstances of Cruelty & perfidy scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages, and totally unworthy the Head of a civilized nation. — He has constrained our fellow Citizens taken Captive on the high seas to bear Arms against their Country, to become the executioners of their friends and Brethren, or to fall themselves by their Hands. — He has excited domestic insurrections amongst us, and has endeavored to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers, the merciless Indian Savages, whose known rule of warfare is an undistinguished destruction of all ages, sexes and conditions. — In every stage of these Oppressions we have Petitioned for Redress in the most humble terms: Our repeated Petitions have been answered by insult and injury. — All Honor, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free People. — Nor have We been wanting in attention to our British brethren. We have warned them from time to time of attempts by their Legislature to extend an unwarrantable Jurisdiction over us. We have reminded them of the circumstances of our emigration and settlement here. We have appealed to their native justice and magnanimity, and we have conjured them by the ties of our common kindred to disavow those usurpations, which would inevitably interrupt our connections and correspondence. They too have been deaf to the voice of justice and of conciliation. We must, therefore, acquiesce in the necessity, which denounces our separation, and hold them, as we hold the rest of mankind, Enemies in War, in Peace Friends. — We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name and by the authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be, Free and Independent States; that they are absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. — And for the support of this Declaration, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

Wm. Smith
Lyman Hall
Geo. Walton

John Hancock
Joseph Hewes
John Adams

Samuel Adams
John Adams
John Adams

John Adams
John Adams
John Adams

John Adams
John Adams
John Adams

John Adams
John Adams
John Adams

Edward R. Mott

George Wythe
Richard Henry Lee
John Jay

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The DECLARATION of INDEPENDENCE

IN CONGRESS, JULY 4, 1776.

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America.

[illegible]

Button Gwinnett
Lynah Hall
Geo Walton.

Yrs. Respect
Joseph Humes,
John P. Dunn

Edward G. Mudge.

Thos. Haynes & Jun
Thomas Lloyd Jun
Arthur Middleton

Samuel Phares

Wth Dear
Thos. Stone

Charles Carroll of Carroll

George Wythe

Richard Henry
St. A. N.

My dear son

Very Respectfully
The Nelsons

Genius Lightfoot Lee
Carver Braxton.

Robt Morris
Benjamin Rush
Wm. Franklin

John Norton

Pa. Smith;

Geo. Taylor

James Wilson
Capt. No. 1

7th Nov 1872
Dear Sir,

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The Mission

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John B. Adams
Wm. Whipple
Saml. Adams
John Adams

Morris Robt. Fraser

Marriage

Slip.

William
P

Wm. H. Rogers
John H. Rogers

Mr. King

Oliver Hopt
Matthew E

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE
DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE OF THE UNITED STATES OF
AMERICA ***

THE DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE OF THE

UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

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Introduction

Written by Michael S. Hart for the official re-release:

The United States Declaration of Independence was the first E-text released by Project Gutenberg, early in 1971. The title was stored in an emailed instruction set which required a tape or diskpack be hand mounted for retrieval. The disk pack was the size of a large cake in a cake carrier, cost \$1500, and contained 5 megabytes, of which this file took 1-2%. Two tape backups were kept plus one on paper tape. The 10,000 files we hope to have online by the end of 2001 should take about 1-2% of a comparably priced drive in 2001.

This file was never copyrighted, Shareware, etc., and is thus for all to use and copy in any manner they choose. Please feel free to make your own edition using this as a base.

In my research for creating this transcription of our first Etext, I have come across enough discrepancies [even within that official documentation provided by the United States] to conclude that even "facsimiles" of the Declaration of Independence are nary identical to the original, nor of other "facsimiles." There is a plethora of variations in capitalizations, punctuation, and where names appear on the documents [which names I have left out].

The resulting document has several misspellings removed from those parchment "facsimiles" I used back in 1971, and which I should not be able to easily find at this time, including "Brittain."

[JT, Apr 2005: "Brittish" is spelled as in the original.]

[R0, Aug 2025: MH's original justified text widths are restored as closely as possible in the introduction. Minor text alterations were made to do so.]

Transcribers' Notes

NOTE: This file contains the original contents of the very first eBook in the Project Gutenberg collection, the Declaration of Independence. This file previously contained a compilation of etexts of #1 and etext #2. The historical variations of etext #1 are included in the "old" subdirectory to be accessed under the "More Files" listing in the landing page for this eBook. No edits or changes have been made to them.

All of the original Project Gutenberg Etexts from the 1970's were produced in ALL CAPS, no lower case. The computers we used then didn't have lower case at all.

This HTML rendition of the original etext #1 was first produced on August 4, 2018, updated August 28, 2025. The styling used simulates the look of the original etext, as presented on computers and terminal displays of the era.

A table of contents and images of Thomas Jefferson's hand-drafted copy of The Declaration of Independence have been added to this HTML presentation.

THE DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE OF THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA

IN CONGRESS, July 4, 1776

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America

When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume, among the Powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty, and the pursuit of Happiness. That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness. Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shown, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future

security. —Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies; and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former Systems of Government. The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.

He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.

He has forbidden his Governors to pass Laws of immediate and pressing importance, unless suspended in their operation till his Assent should be obtained; and when so suspended, he has utterly neglected to attend to them.

He has refused to pass other Laws for the accommodation of large districts of people, unless those people would relinquish the right of Representation in the Legislature, a right inestimable to them and formidable to tyrants only.

He has called together legislative bodies at places unusual, uncomfortable, and distant from the depository of their Public Records, for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measures.

He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people.

He has refused for a long time, after such dissolutions, to cause others to be elected; whereby the Legislative Powers, incapable of Annihilation, have returned to the People at large for their exercise; the State remaining in the mean time exposed to all the dangers of invasion from without, and convulsions within.

He has endeavoured to prevent the population of these States; for that purpose obstructing the Laws of Naturalization of Foreigners; refusing to pass others to encourage their migration hither, and raising the conditions of new Appropriations of Lands.

He has obstructed the Administration of Justice, by refusing his Assent to Laws for establishing Judiciary Powers.

He has made judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries.

He has erected a multitude of New Offices, and sent hither swarms of Officers to harass our People, and eat out their substance.

He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures.

He has affected to render the Military independent of and superior to the Civil Power.

He has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitution, and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his Assent to their Acts of pretended legislation:

For quartering large bodies of armed troops among us:

For protecting them, by a mock Trial, from Punishment for any Murders which they should commit on the Inhabitants of these States:

For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world:

For imposing taxes on us without our Consent:

For depriving us, in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury:

For transporting us beyond Seas to be tried for pretended offences:

For abolishing the free System of English Laws in a neighbouring Province, establishing therein an Arbitrary

government, and enlarging its Boundaries so as to render it at once an example and fit instrument for introducing the same absolute rule into these Colonies:

For taking away our Charters, abolishing our most valuable Laws, and altering fundamentally the Forms of our Governments:

For suspending our own Legislatures, and declaring themselves invested with Power to legislate for us in all cases whatsoever.

He has abdicated Government here, by declaring us out of his Protection and waging War against us.

He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns, and destroyed the lives of our people.

He is at this time transporting large armies of foreign mercenaries to compleat the works of death, desolation and tyranny, already begun with circumstances of Cruelty & perfidy scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages, and totally unworthy of the Head of a civilized nation.

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Nor have We been wanting in attention to our British brethren. We have warned them from time to time of attempts by their

legislature to extend an unwarrantable jurisdiction over us. We have reminded them of the circumstances of our emigration and settlement here. We have appealed to their native justice and magnanimity, and we have conjured them by the ties of our common kindred to disavow these usurpations, which would inevitably interrupt our connections and correspondence. They too have been deaf to the voice of justice and of consanguinity. We must, therefore, acquiesce in the necessity, which denounces our Separation, and hold them, as we hold the rest of mankind, Enemies in War, in Peace Friends.

We, therefore, the Representatives of the United States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by the Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the Protection of Divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

THOMAS JEFFERSON'S HANDWRITTEN DRAFTS

The following four images are of engravings taken from Jefferson's draft of the Declaration of Independence, in his handwriting with emendations in the handwritings of Benjamin Franklin and John Adams. Tapping the "ENLARGE" button will display the image in full-size.

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ENLARGE PAGE 1

ENLARGE PAGE 2

ENLARGE PAGE 3

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ENLARGE PAGE 4

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AMERICA ***

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A Declaration by the Representatives of the UNITED STATES
OF AMERICA, in General Congress assembled.

When in the course of human events it becomes necessary for ^{one} people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to ~~assume among the powers of the earth the separate and equal station to which the laws of nature & of nature's god entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.~~

We hold these truths to be ^{self-evident}, that all men are created equal & independent; that ^{they are endowed by their creator with equal} rights, that among ^{these} are ~~life, liberty, & the pursuit of happiness~~; that to secure these ^{rights}, governments are instituted among men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed; that whenever any form of government ~~shall~~ becomes destructive of these ends, it is the right of the people to alter or to abolish it, & to institute new government, laying its foundation on such principles, & organising its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their safety & happiness. prudence indeed will dictate that governments long established should not be changed for light & transient causes: and accordingly all experience hath shewn that mankind are more disposed to suffer while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. but when a long train of abuses & usurpations, [begun at a distinguished period, &] pursuing invariably the same object, evinces a design to ~~reduce~~ ^{under absolute Despotism} them to ~~absolute Despotism~~, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such government & to provide new guards for their future security. such has been the patient sufferance of these colonies; & such is now the necessity which constrains them to ^{alter} ~~expunge~~ their former systems of government. the history of ^{the} present ^{King of Great Britain} ~~usurpation~~ is a history of ^{repeated} [unremitting] injuries and usurpations, [among which, ^{appears no solitary fact} ~~for it is a solitary fact~~ to contradict the uniform tenor of the rest, ^{but all} ~~all of which~~ ^{having} in direct object the establishment of an absolute tyranny over these states. to prove this, let facts be submitted to a candid world, [for the truth of which we pledge a faith yet unsullied by falsehood]

* Dr. Franklin's handwriting

* Mr. Adams's handwriting

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he has refused his assent to laws the most wholesome and necessary for the pub-

-lic good:

he has forbidden his governors to pass laws of immediate & pressing importance, unless suspended in their operation till his assent should be obtained, and when so suspended, he has ^{utterly} neglected ~~attending~~ to attend to them.

he has refused to pass other laws for the accomodation of large districts of people unless those people would relinquish the right of ^{in the legislature} representation, a right inestimable to them & formidable to tyrants only:

he has called together legislative bodies at places unusual, uncomfortable, & distant from the depository of their public records, for the sole purpose of fatiguing them into compliance with his measures;

he has dissolved Representative houses repeatedly ^[& continually] for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people:

~~he has refused~~ ^{time after time} he has refused for a long ~~space of time~~ ^{Disputation} to cause others to be elected, whereby the legislative powers, incapable of annihilation, have returned to the people at large for their exercise, the state remaining in the mean time exposed to all the dangers of invasion from without & convulsions within:

* Mr. Adams

he has endeavored to prevent the population of these states; for that purpose obstructing the laws for naturalization of foreigners; refusing to pass others to encourage their migrations hither, & raising the conditions of new ap-
-propriations of lands:

he has ^{obstructed} ~~suffered~~ the administration of justice ^{totally} to cease in some of these ~~states~~ ^{states}, refusing his assent to laws for establishing judiciary powers:

he has made ^{our} judges dependant on his will alone, for the tenure of their offices, ^{the} & ^{payment} amount of their salaries:

+ Dr. Franklin

he has erected a multitude of new offices ^[by a self-assumed power] & sent hither swarms of officers to harass our people & eat out their substance:

he has kept among us in times of peace, standing armies ^{[without the consent of our} ^{the} ^{legislatures} ~~ships of war~~ ^{ships of war]}:

he has affected to render the military independent of & superior to the civil power:

he has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitu-
-tions and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his assent to their ^{acts of} ~~pretended~~ ^{acts of} ~~acts of~~

of legislation, for quartering large bodies of armed troops among us;

for protecting them by a mock-trial from punishment for any murders ^{which} they should commit on the inhabitants of these states;

for cutting off our trade with all parts of the world;

for imposing taxes on us without our consent:

for depriving us ^{in many cases} of the benefits of trial by jury

for transporting us beyond seas to be tried for pretended offences:

for abolishing the free system of English laws in a neighboring province, establishing therein an arbitrary government and enlarging it's borders, so as to render it at once an example & fit instrument for introducing the same abominable

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+ Dr. Franklin

abolishing our most ^{valuable} ~~important~~ laws
for taking away our charters & altering fundamentally the forms of our governments,
for suspending our own legislatures & declaring themselves invested with power to
legislate for us in all cases whatsoever;
he has abdicated government here, ^{by declaring us out of his protection & warring against us.} withdrawing his governors, & declaring us out
of his allegiance & protection.]
he has plundered our seas, ravaged our coasts, burnt our towns & destroyed the
lives of our people:
he is at this time transporting large armies of ^{Scotch and other} foreign mercenaries to complete
the works of death, desolation & tyranny already begun with circumstances
^{scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages and totally}
of cruelty & perfidy, unworthy the head of a civilized nation:
^{he has excited domestic insurrections amongst us and has}
he has endeavored to bring on the inhabitants of our frontiers the merciless Indian
savages, whose known rule of warfare is an undistinguished destruction of
all ages, sexes, & conditions [of existence:]
[he has incited treasonable insurrections of our fellow-citizens, with the
allurements of forfeiture & confiscation of our property;
<sup>he has constrained others to follow him in his hostile and unchristianlike high seas to bear arms against their country & to do
him & his party the business of his enemies. to become the executioners of their friends & brethren</sup>
he has waged cruel war against human nature itself, violating it's most sa-
cred rights of life & liberty in the persons of a distant people who never of-
fended him, captivating & carrying them into slavery in another hemis-
phere, or to incur miserable death in their transportation thither. This
piratical warfare, the opprobrium of infidel powers, is the warfare of the
Christian king of Great Britain determined to keep open a market
where MEN should be bought & sold. he has prostituted his negative
for suppressing every legislative attempt to prohibit or to restrain this
^{determining to keep upon a market where MEN should be bought & sold.}
execrable commerce; and that this assemblage of horrors might want no fact
of distinguished die, he is now exciting those very people to rise in arms
among us, and to purchase that liberty of which he has deprived them,
by murdering the people upon whom he also abused them: thus paying
off former crimes committed against the liberties of one people, with crimes
which he urges them to commit against the lives of another.]

Dr. Franklin

in every stage of these oppressions we have petitioned for redress in the most humble
terms; our repeated petitions have been answered ^{only} by repeated injuries. a prince
whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a tyrant, is unfit
to be the ruler of a ^{free} people [who mean to be free] future ages will scarce believe
that the hardiness of one man, adventured within the short compass of twelve years
to lay a foundation for broad & undisguised, for tyranny
only, ~~to lay a foundation for broad & undisguised, for tyranny~~ over a people fostered & fixed in principles
of liberty, freedom.]

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Nor have we been wanting in attentions to our British brethren. we have warned them from time to time of attempts by their legislature to extend ^{an unwarrantable} a jurisdiction over ^{us} [these our states] we have reminded them of the circumstances of our emigration & settlement here, [no one of which could warrant so strange a pretension: that these were effected at the expence of our own blood & treasure, unassisted by the wealth or the strength of Great Britain: that in constituting indeed our several forms of government, we had adopted one common king, thereby laying a foundation for perpetual league & amity with them: but that submission to their parliament was no part of our constitution, nor ever in idea if history may be credited: and] ^{have} we appealed to their native justice & magnanimity, ^{if we have conquered them} [as well as to] the ties of our common kindred to disavow these usurpations which ^{would inevitably} [were likely to] interrupt our ^{connection &} correspondence. ~~connection~~. They too have been deaf to the voice of justice & of consanguinity, ^{we must therefore} [when occasions have been given them, by the regular course of their laws, of removing from their councils the disturbers of our harmony, they have by their free election re-established them in power. at this very time too they are permitting their chief magistrate to send over not only soldiers of our common blood, but Scotch & foreign mercenaries to invade ^{destroy us} ~~us~~ ^{as we hold} ~~us~~. these facts have given the last stab to agonizing affection, and manly spirit bids us to renounce for ever these unfeeling brethren. we must endeavor to forget our former love for them, and to hold them as we hold the rest of mankind, enemies in war, in peace friends we might have been a free & a great people together; but a communication of grandeur & of freedom it seems is below their dignity. be it so since they will have it: the road to ^{to glory} ~~glory~~ & happiness, is open to us too; we will ~~not~~ ^{must} tread it ~~on~~ ^{apart from them}, and ^{we must therefore} acquiesce in the necessity which ^{de-} ~~pronounces~~ ^{and hold them as we hold the rest of mankind enemies in war, in peace friends} our ~~separation~~ ^{separation}!

We therefore the representatives of the United States of America in General Congress assembled, ^{appealing to the reasoning part of the world for the rectitude of our intentions} do in the name & by authority of the good people of these ^{colonies} [states]

[reject and renounce all allegiance & subjection to the kings of Great Britain ^{a different phraseology inserted} & all others who may hereafter claim by, through, or under them; we utterly dissolve & ~~break off~~ ^{have} all political connection which may ~~have~~ ^{have} heretofore ^{sub-} sisted between us & the people or parliament of Great Britain; and finally we do assert and declare these colonies to be free and independant states, and that as free & independant states they shall ~~hereafter~~ ^{full} have power to levy war conclude peace, contract alliances, establish commerce, & to do all other acts and things which independant states may of right do. And for the support of this declaration] we mutually pledge to each other our lives, our fortunes, & our sacred honour.

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